

GENERAL STUDIES - 4
ASCEND TEST 14

Time Allowed: **Three Hours**

Maximum Marks: **250**

Question Paper Specific Instructions:

1. There are **12** questions printed in **ENGLISH**.
 2. All questions are compulsory.
 3. The number of marks carried by a question/part is indicated against it.
 4. Word limit in questions, if specified, should be adhered to.
 5. Any page or portion of the page left blank in the Question-Cum Answer Booklet must be clearly Struck off.
 6. Do furnish the appropriate details in the answer sheet (viz. Name, Email, Roll No, Mobile).
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Q1. (a) "Contentment is the foundation of true happiness." Do you agree? What does contentment mean to you? Illustrate with examples. (10 marks, 150 words)

(b) "Attitude shapes our perceptions and intentions, while behavior is the visible manifestation of these internal states through real-world actions." Discuss. (10 marks, 150 words)

Q2. (a) Probity in governance is essential for socio-economic development, without which true progress cannot be achieved in a nation." Illustrate with examples. (10 marks, 150 words)

(b) "Tolerance is about how your beliefs influence the way you treat those who disagree with you." Discuss the role of tolerance in promoting social harmony in society. (10 marks, 150 words)

Q3. (a) Discuss how Emotional Intelligence (EI) can enhance the effectiveness of civil servants. Suggest measures that civil servants can adopt to improve their EI. (10 marks, 150 words)

(b) Analyze the relationship between corporate governance and ethical practices in the private sector. How can companies align their profit-making goals with ethical values and social responsibility? (10 marks, 150 words)

Q4. (a) Evaluate the role of international funding agencies in promoting ethical practices and good governance globally. How can they ensure funds are used effectively and ethically? (10 marks, 150 words)

(b) Does technological development contribute to the advancement of ethical standards in society? Discuss. (10 marks, 150 words)

Q5. (a) Assess the effectiveness of 'information sharing and transparency' mechanisms in promoting good governance. What are the potential limitations and challenges of implementing these measures? (10 marks, 150 words)

(b) Analyse how conscience contributes to upholding personal integrity and fostering moral responsibility. (10 marks, 150 words)

Q6. What do the following quotations mean to you in the present context and context of public service.

(a) "In a gentle way, you can shake the world." – Mahatma Gandhi.

(10 marks, 150 words)

(b) "There is no chance for the welfare of the world unless the condition of women is improved. It is not possible for a bird to fly on one wing." – Swami Vivekananda.

(10 marks, 150 words)

(c) "Let me not pray to be sheltered from dangers, but to be fearless in facing them. Let me not beg for the stilling of my pain, but for the heart to conquer it." – Rabindranath Tagore.

(10 marks, 150 words)

Section B

Q7. Mr. Anil, a dedicated and experienced civil servant, was recently appointed as the Secretary of the Public Works Department (PWD) in Bihar. Upon taking on this new role, Mr. Anil aimed to bring about positive changes in the department, focusing on enhancing the quality of infrastructure and ensuring the safety of the public. However, within just three months of his tenure, a series of alarming incidents have brought the state's infrastructure under intense scrutiny as 15 bridges have collapsed across Bihar causing significant financial losses, injuries, and tragic loss of lives.

These incidents have exposed severe deficiencies in the quality of infrastructure and highlighted a glaring lack of proper oversight and accountability within the PWD. Alarmed by these failures, the State Government formed an inquiry committee and appointed Mr. Anil as its head, considering his dedication to public service, to uncover the truth.

As the investigation progressed, Mr. Anil and his team uncovered a disturbing pattern of corruption and negligence. It became evident that the minister responsible for the PWD and the former PWD chairman, who is now serving as the chief secretary of the state, were deeply involved in corrupt practices. The investigation revealed that substandard materials were used in construction, and the mandatory quality checks were bypassed or falsified, all under the protection of these senior officials.

The situation has now escalated into a major public scandal. The media has extensively covered the issue, and the public outraged by the negligence and corruption is demanding accountability and justice for the victims. On the one hand, there is a strong public expectation for a thorough and transparent inquiry that would

hold those responsible, regardless of their position, accountable for their actions. On the other hand, Mr. Anil is facing significant internal pressure from his seniors within the government. Several high-ranking officials are advising him to conduct a lenient inquiry.

Mr. Anil faces a difficult choice i.e. to uphold honesty & integrity by thoroughly investigating and holding responsible officials accountable, or yield to pressure from his superiors by conducting a lenient inquiry to protect powerful interests over truth and justice. Mr. Anil choice could either restore public trust in the administration or further erode confidence in the state's governance.

- a) Evaluate the options available to Mr. Anil in the above situation and decide which he should follow.
- b) Why are issues persistent in public service delivery?
- c) Suggest measures so strengthen public service delivery

(20 marks, 250 words)

Q8. Mr. Varun, who recently completed his law degree, aims to help society by providing free legal aid to the poor and marginalized. He dreams of one day delivering justice from the position of a judge of the supreme court. To achieve this, Mr. Varun joined a prestigious senior lawyer as a junior lawyer.

During his training, a case comes up related to a tragic car accident caused by a teenager. The teenager is a son of a prominent businessman with connections to politicians and high-profile judges, who received bail from the Juvenile Justice Board. The penalty imposed was notably lenient, raising concerns about the fairness of the judicial process and disparity in punishments.

As a trainee lawyer working under the counsel representing the accused, Mr. Varun is aware of complex dynamics. He came to know that the judge overseeing the case was being offered a large sum of money and a favorable post in the future. This situation led to a lenient judgment for the teenager, raising serious concerns about judicial integrity and potential corruption.

Varun's professional ethics compel him to address this issue. Varun decided to report it to the Bar Council of India. However, this action carries significant risks, including potential repercussions from powerful individuals connected to the case that could jeopardize his legal career. Despite these risks, Varun feels a strong moral imperative to stand up for justice.

- a) Discuss the ethical issues involved in the case.
 - b) Critically evaluate the options available to Mr. Varun in the above situation.
 - c) Suggest judicial reforms to improve accountability and address corruption within the judiciary
- (20 marks, 250 words)

Q9. Mr. Harish, the Chairperson of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), has recently been overburdened with multiple complaints from investors and business houses. The complaints highlight concerns that reports published by certain foreign companies are influencing market reactions, leading to significant financial losses for investors. These reports often make bold claims or provide analyses that create panic or speculation among investors, prompting them to buy or sell shares hastily.

Over time, a troubling pattern has emerged. Almost every instance where these foreign companies release a report, subsequent investigations reveal that they are involved in manipulating share prices for their personal gain. This manipulation often involves short-selling shares before releasing a negative report, allowing these companies to profit when share prices drop following their publications. This pattern is not only evident but deeply disturbing, as it undermines the integrity of the financial markets and erodes investor trust.

- a) What are the key issues involved in this case?
- b) What measures can SEBI implement to prevent future manipulation of the market by foreign entities.

(20 marks, 250 words)

Q10. Mr. X is the Operations Head at Exotic Spices, a company renowned for its high-quality spice blends. Recently, Mr. X observed the inclusion of a new ingredient in the spice mix, which was not previously part of the company's recipes. On further investigation through a laboratory analysis, Mr. X discovered that this new ingredient enhances the flavor of the spices, potentially giving the company a competitive edge in the market.

As part of the company's standard quality control measures, a random sampling test was conducted, revealing a disturbing fact: the new ingredient contains a carcinogenic element. Concerned about the potential health risks, Mr. X promptly informed the company's CEO about the findings. The CEO acknowledged the information but expressed a different concern. He highlighted that the introduction of this new ingredient had significantly boosted the company's sales, especially in overseas markets like Hong Kong and Singapore, where the products were recording high profits.

The CEO, understanding the gravity of the situation, admitted to Mr. X that officials from the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) had been bribed to overlook the carcinogenic elements in the spice mix, ensuring that the product continued to be sold domestically without any regulatory hiccups. The CEO then pressured Mr. X to remain silent about the matter, emphasizing the financial gains the company was reaping.

But soon the news about the presence of a carcinogenic pesticide, ethylene oxide, in several spice mixes of Exotic Spices broke out in the international market. The story

quickly gained traction, leading to a public outcry and the subsequent imposition of a ban on the company's products in various countries.

With the company's reputation severely damaged and the international market in turmoil, the Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) of Exotic Spices intervened to conduct a formal inquiry into the matter. As the inquiry progresses, Mr. X finds himself under immense pressure from the CEO and other high-ranking officials to downplay his findings and to provide statements that could mitigate the situation.

- a) What options does Mr. X have in dealing with the situation at hand? Evaluate these options and suggest the best way out.
- b) Highlight the ethical dilemmas involved in Food Safety & Standard and suggest a way forward.

(20 marks, 250 words)

Q11. You were selected for the prestigious Civil Services Examination (CSE) alongside a friend with whom you shared accommodation during the preparation phase.

But during the medical examination, you found out that your roommate had submitted a fake medical certificate and forged identity documentation. Despite knowing this you chose to ignore the issue, rationalizing that the selection process had concluded.

As you progressed through the training phase, a crisis of conscience began to trouble you. The awareness that a deserving candidate is excluded from the final selection list due to the fraudulent actions of your roommate weighed heavily on your conscience. The ethical implications of the fraud and its impact on the fairness of the selection process became increasingly impacting you.

Determined to address this issue, you decided to write a letter to the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) to expose the fraud and act as a whistleblower. However, as a newly recruited probationary officer, you feared the potential repercussions of such a move. The prospect of opening a "Pandora's box" was daunting, with the possibility of uncovering numerous other instances of fraud. You worried that this could lead to widespread investigations, possibly sidelining you within your own fraternity and subjecting you to severe criticism from your colleagues.

The fear of professional isolation and the negative impact on your career further compounded your dilemma. On the one hand, you felt a moral obligation to report the misconduct and uphold the integrity of the selection process. On the other hand, the potential personal and professional fallout from exposing the issue made you hesitant.

- a) Discuss the Ethical Issues involved in the case.
- b) Evaluate the options available to you and recommend which one you would choose, also explaining your reasoning.

- c) What strategies can be implemented to nudge aspiring civil servants towards ethical conduct?

(20 marks, 250 words)

Q12. As a renowned financial influencer with a large online following, you have earned a reputation for providing quality investment advice. Your followers trust your insights, often making investment decisions based on your recommendations.

Blackbuck Fintech, a leading company in the digital payments sector known for its innovative and secure payment solutions, approaches you for a partnership. They seek to leverage your influence to attract more investors. Seeing potential in the digital payments market, you conduct due diligence and agree to endorse their stocks.

Initially, your followers respond positively, leading to a rise in Blackbuck Fintech's stock value. However, the government then introduces new compliance requirements for the digital payments industry on financial reporting and data protection. These regulations create significant operational challenges for Blackbuck Fintech, negatively impacting its market presence and hindering expansion plans. As a result of the stricter financial reporting norms, the company's financial mismanagement comes to light, revealing discrepancies in its financial statements and raising concerns about its financial integrity.

As these challenges mount, Blackbuck Fintech's stock value plummets, causing substantial financial losses for your followers who invested based on your endorsement. The situation deteriorates further, leading to public criticism and a loss of trust in your recommendations.

Regulatory investigations begin to scrutinize your endorsement of Blackbuck Fintech, focusing on your due diligence and potential conflicts of interest. As your followers' express disappointment and frustration, your reputation and credibility as a trusted financial influencer are at stake.

- a) What are the ethical issues involved in this case.
- b) What steps should be taken by the influencer to ethically respond to such a situation?
- c) Propose a code of conduct for influencers to follow when they are endorsing financial products.

(20 marks, 250 words)